Kraig Marwick’s Music Blog

Cruise - Band rehearsal - 2/9/25
03 September 2025 3:00 PM
Rehearsed with band at Captain Toms, Ann Street, Aberdeen from 7pm - 9pm.

Playing rhythm guitar and providing vocals, we ran through a setlist of 7 established songs (originals, written by myself) as a refresher. Nothing new introduced this week due to the sudden departure of our singer.

The Source, Getaway, Kick Myself, Dunno, Even Steven, Adored, Lost Today

The Source definitely requires more practice as i kept forgetting the vocal cues and some of the lyrics.

1 cover 'Columbia' by Oasis was also performed.

Practice was a little rusty. Our original singer recently departed the band, so i have taken the responsibility for the time being. Will need time to get used to singing the songs again while playing guitar as i'd previously only done backing vocal for choruses etc.

Cruise band rehearsal 16/09/2025
17 September 2025 9:30 AM
Rehearsal from 7-9pm at Captain Toms, Ann Street, Aberdeen.

Introduced a new song to the band called 'Everything'.

Explained chord progression and structure. Played each part of the song (intro into verse, chorus, bridge and middle 8, then ending). Played the song through a couple of times, with mistakes. Decided to transpose song up a full step to help with vocal range. We played it through again a couple of times in the new key. Decided to move on from this, everyone confirmed they were happy and familiar with structure and melody. It will be revisited on our next rehearsal and refined further.

Went through our usual set of songs, had a brief discussion regarding lead guitar parts as these will need to be made consistent prior to any recording. At the moment, the lead guitarist is never playing the same thing twice during solos.

It was good to discuss things and move some idea’s around; it’s one of the reasons I wanted to join a band. Musical conversations always bring a smile to my face, even if they aren’t always positive. It helps my own musical development and helps me understand things I usually wouldn’t, it can be helped by context or just asking “what do you mean?” I love that it’s a safe, constructive space for discussion and no-one feels offended or ‘precious’ about feedback.

Cruise band rehearsal 7th October
08 October 2025 1:09 PM
Everything was revisited with the capo on the 3rd fret. I agreed to learn the song without the use of the capo, so i need to write out the new chord structure. The transposition was causing a bit of confusion with the other band members, like the bass, so it was agreed we'd revisit once i wrote out the new chords as opposed to just trying to play everything higher up.

This highlighted the importance of making sure everyone in the band is working from the same chord structure. Using a capo might make things easier for me, but it can create confusion for other instruments like bass, so writing everything out properly will make rehearsals more efficient.

Waking Dream song developement
17 October 2025 1:29 PM
After purchasing an Arturia Minilab3 MIDI player i could start to work out chords to use for Waking Dream, I've settled on starting with Gm, i think the tone of the song should be minor, but getting the tempo right is proving to be a challenge.

I decided to work on chords for now and work out tempo as i go, so i have the Gm, Dm, F chords and a small lead piece at the end of each phrase. I know in my head how i would like the chorus to go but i am struggling to find the right chord to move into, limited by my own keyboard skills i guess.

Bless This Mess song development
22 October 2025 1:38 PM
I've been working on this song and using my new MIDI player, i have been adding MIDI in chords and lead for a short instrumental section of the song. I used the musictheory.net site to work out how to shape the chords, which essentially match the guitar chords of G, C and D with Em and Bm in the chorus.

My lack of keyboard skills are pretty obvious!!

Bless This Mess
30 October 2025 1:44 PM
I've been working on this song and managed to record most of it into my DAW. The MIDI tracks i played into it could be modified to change impact, timing and length of notes. Messing about with these things has shown some timing issues in the guitar playing,

however, so i decided to re record the acoustic guitar. I've shared the song with Liz, who i've asked to provide some vocals. I sent her mp3 files of all the stems and a full mix, with a lyric sheet as well.

Will wait till she has time to record a vocal and see how it goes.

New song 'Waking Dream'
01 November 2025 7:30 AM
I have lyrics for a new song I've called Waking Dream. I also have an idea of melody and how i would like it to sound, although this is still currently in my head. The structure (at present) is -

4 bar Intro, Verse, Chorus, 4 bar Instrumental, Verse, Chorus, 8 bar Instrumental, Chorus

I'd like the song to be introduced on a piano or keyboard sound, so using the link from musictheory.net below, and the document i have created showing chord and scale formula, I will work out how to find the correct chords for what i want to achieve.

My initial step is to sing the start of the song and see which key it fits with. This will give me the starting point to work out the desired progression (this key can then be adjusted to suit other vocal styles). Once the opening chords have been established i can work out the verse with the lyrics and move onto the chorus to translate into the style I want to achieve.

I'll be using Presonus Studio 1 to record everything i need to and add layers. Once the song is finalised, I'll make the edits in Studio 1, then it will be mixed and mastered. This song will be part of my graded unit, from its conception to its release.

Waking Dream Composition
08 December 2025 2:00 PM
I've composed a verse using MIDI and put it into my DAW for Waking Dream. I'm finding it difficult to find the chords to move into the chorus the way i'd like to. I know what sound i want to go for but i just can't seem to find it, which is frustrating.

Meanwhile, i have another song which i had lyrics for. I've essentially mapped this song entirely on the acoustic guitar, i feel there is definitely scope for collaboration as i think a female accompaniment would work really well. The song is called Bless This Mess.

While it’s great to have different ideas floating around, I can be easily distracted. Bless This Mess is developing faster naturally, so I keep going back to it. This is influencing some of the work I am supposed to be doing for my HNC.

Bless This Mess
15 December 2025 4:09 PM
Bless This Mess has been taking on a life of its own, I've completed a rough recording on my DAW and using some of the information on musictheory.net - Lessons I've developed some MIDI tracks to accompany. There's a small instrumental piece after the first chorus and accompanying chords. Since this is making more progress than Waking Dream, I am considering using this song in the graded unit instead of Waking Dream.

This has made me realise the importance of focusing on the strongest ideas rather than trying to force a piece that wasn't developing as well. Compared to Waking Dream, this song had a clearer structure and felt more natural to build on, so choosing it for the graded unit will be a more effective way to demonstrate my skills.

16th December - Live performance
16 December 2025 10:30 AM
Discussed doing a live performance over teams for the Christmas concert. I'd spoke the previous day about trying everything out today and making sure i could get the feed to work properly and ensure it worked from the Fort William side.

I called Rachel on teams, confirmed everything was working ok.....she turned the camera to a full class and said 'go for it' - panic ensued!! I was not prepared for it so i was a tad nervous. Ran through an acoustic version of Kick Myself where i changed the strum pattern to add a bit more dynamics since it is just one guitar and my own voice.

I think this has taught me to expect the unexpected, sometimes, and be ready for things to change. I'm glad I'd done a little bit of rehearsal myself before making the call, but I'd still say I wasn't as ready as I could have been.

Everything - return to this song
20 December 2025 3:35 PM
Due to the fact we haven't been able to meet as a band for some time, I thought I would revisit Everything. I was still shifting words around in the second verse and i never had a solid recording of it because when I tried to, I'd mess up the words I kept changing!

That twinned with trying to play the transposed chords without the capo was making it frustrating and difficult to get it right. I did manage to get a rough recording that I agreed with myself I'd come back to. Time will be a factor over the next month due to the Christmas break and my returning offshore on the 3rd of January, i don't think I'll get very much done over the next month.

This highlighted the importance of committing to a fixed arrangement before recording, as constantly changing lyrics made it difficult to achieve a clean performance. It also showed that transposing without a capo introduced unnecessary difficulty, which impacted both accuracy and confidence while playing. In future, I would finalise lyrics and choose the most practical playing method before attempting to record.

Exiting Cruise
16 January 2026 5:58 PM
I made the really difficult decision to remove myself from the band, I contacted the other members on our group chat and it truly breaks my heart.

I've really been struggling to balance my work, study and family life and have felt the expectation on me. I felt the band had stagnated and we were finding it really difficult to find time for it. I have loads of ideas and songs written but i was never getting the time to develop them and introduce them to the band properly. I felt I was holding them back a bit because we were still playing the same songs as before and really having trouble finding a singer.

It was stressing me out quite badly, so I made the decision to step back.

On reflection, it has lifted a weight from my shoulders because I can concentrate on everything at my own pace and in my own way. When I need collaboration I can ask from the band (there were no hard feelings on my departure) or my fellow students.

Getting back to (music) work!
23 January 2026 1:56 PM
Start of the year and progress has been very slow. Extended periods of bad weather meant I spent a week in the heliport trying to get offshore and was unable to progress anything. Got home from offshore after some nightshift, any progress is going to be difficult, i missed the initial classes of the year which would have laid out the tasks for the new classes for this term.

Reviewing course work and tasks required for the upcoming term. I felt a bit overwhelmed from missing out on so much and have the fear of falling behind.

Bless This Mess....again
02 February 2026 12:00 PM
Tried to set up remote sharing to do some live work with Liz, frustratingly we couldn't get it to work. Can get audio to move in one direction which means we can't get the collaboration to work.

Looking at getting myself down to Fort William to progress with some of the more challenging aspects of remote working.

Bless This Mess – Vocal Arrangement Development

15 February 2026 2:30 PM

While continuing to develop *Bless This Mess*, I spent some time refining the vocal arrangement. My initial idea was to structure the song as a full male/female duet throughout. However, after experimenting with different approaches, I adjusted this to create more variation and contrast within the track.

The next version had the male vocal leading for two verses and choruses, followed by the female vocal taking the lead for the next section, before bringing both voices together for the final chorus and outro. The intention behind this was to create a call-and-response style dynamic between the two vocalists.

During the mixing process, I accidentally discovered what became the final arrangement while muting different vocal tracks to make edits. I found that allowing the female vocal to take a solo verse immediately after the instrumental section created a much stronger dynamic shift.

This version combined the strongest elements of the previous ideas. The contrast between the male-led opening and the female-led section added emotional depth, while the duet in the final chorus helped to bring the song to a more impactful conclusion.

This process highlighted the importance of experimentation during mixing, and how creative decisions can sometimes emerge unintentionally through the editing process.

It was at this point I had to accept I had oversubscribed what I could do in the time. I made the decision to focus on Kick Myself, which was a well-established song and I'd played it several times live as well as having a few recordings of it in different stages of development. Bless This Mess was my other point of focus, purely because it presented so many opportunities for learning and collaborating and it felt great hearing the song take shape the way it was.

I decided the song Everything would not be a main feature in my portfolio. It is fully written and I know the arrangement, I just feel the other evidence required will take too long for me to complete. I'd prefer to hand in something of quality than have more songs and evidence with less effort applied to them.

Visit to Fort William
23 February 2026 3:54 PM
Finally made it to Fort William to meet everyone in person. Glad to be here, although i've not had a chance to work on my own music i was given the opportunity to work with Sandy and Mary-Anne with one of Sandy's projects. Chords were simple and it was in 4/4 time but the style was different from what i'm used to playing so it was good to be involved in something that took me out of my comfort zone a little bit.

We went through the song a few times and by the end of the session, managed to play through the intro, verse and outro in the original key. Sandy spoke about the idea of a key change in the middle of the song, moving up a fifth, which we briefly explored.

Visit to Fort William - day 2
24 February 2026 12:00 PM
Finally got to meet Liz in person and rehearse Bless This Mess with her in the live room. It went really well and i was able to get a decent recording on my phone. I gave her the lyric sheet for Kick Myself too and we gave that a try with Liz just providing backing vocals in the chorus. It went quite well again, considering she hadn't heard the song before.

I met Ally for the first time too, he announced that there would be Houseplant sessions taking place on Wednesday and i could perform if i wanted too - i agreed, it would be a great new experience to be front and centre, as any performances i've done in the past, i've been rhythm guitar and backing vocals. This will be a great opportunity and a new challenge.

Visit to Fort William - day 3
25 February 2026 5:00 PM
More practicing with Lizzie in the live room, we rehearsed Bless This Mess and Kick Myself. Both were great, so we committed to playing them in the Houseplant Sessions that afternoon.

Having met most of the other students, i thought i'd try and take advantage of some of their musical skills for Bless This Mess. I figured if i could get someone to play the piano and someone to do the violin phrase, it would be fantastic to play that live together.

I put a message on our group chat and Leon and Mary-Anne agreed to learn the song, i was hoping to revisit Fort William again at the end of March. I sent them the Lyric Sheet and the demo i had from my DAW, with as much information about chords and notes as i could give them too.

I played the 2 songs we had been rehearsing and they were both captured on video, i was very happy to have done it despite some nerves before hand when Ally informed me it was the biggest Houseplant crowd he'd ever seen!

Second visit to Fort William - day 1
30 March 2026 2:58 PM
Revisited Fort William so i could participate in the live performance on 1Tuesday.

Walked into class and the first thing i heard was my song Bless This Mess being played in one of the practice rooms - i was delighted! I managed to get in with Leon, Mary-Anne and Lizzie and we went through it a couple of times. It was really good, there was a small phrase in the middle of the instrumental we had to discuss the timing on (it was a chord change that usually has 4 bars but only has 2 in this part) but we got it sorted out quite quickly. I was incredibly impressed with Leon's talent on the keys, he asked if it was ok for him to improvise a bit and i agreed it added some amazing texture to the song and the performance.

We rehearsed Wild Mountain Thyme together, which i was very relieved that we did. I had played along to Rachel's recording and knew the chords and mostly the structure but it was worthwhile playing it with everyone else - it sounded amazing too, the class is full of really talented people. It's an honour to be given the chance to play with these folks!!

In the afternoon we followed Sandy's lead and got the stage set up for tomorrows performance. There was a lot of cables and it was handy to have a basic understanding of signal flow and stage set-up, Sandy did a great job of keeping everyone right and setting up the live mixing board in a logical manner. It was really helpful to see the stage being set-up for a live performance and reinforced knowledge we had gained earlier in the course about signal flow and live sound set-up

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Live performance - Fort William
31 March 2026 5:30 PM
We started the day with a vocal warm up with Rachel, which was a lot of fun. It's something i should be doing much more of if i want to sing, but it's not an easy thing to do in a house full of people.

We ran through Wild Mountain Thyme a couple more times, it sounds brilliant when everyone is involved! I spent much of the morning practicing the songs i wanted to perform - i'd chosen to do a cover of Sad Song, an early b-side, by Oasis. I was reluctant to play the same two songs i had on my previous visit.

The afternoon was the performance, i played Sad Song solo, i must admit i made an early mistake which led to a few more throughout the song, which i was a bit disappointed about, but i was told it wasn't noticeable and i kept playing through them so i think i got away with it. It shows the importance of keeping composure throughout live performances to maintain the professionalism of the show and keep the performance intact.

Bless This Mess was an absolute joy to play with the other guys and it could not have gone better, i was made up ti have been able to do that.

I watched the other performances, which was great, there was a real variety of styles and genres. The final act was Wild Mountain Thyme, which was a really good way to top things off, it was a beautiful moment and i was proud to be part of it.

Final Blog Entry
13 April 2026 3:34 PM
Over the course of this project, I developed my skills in songwriting, recording and live performance. I improved my understanding of music theory through scoring and transposition, and developed my production skills through DAW recording and mixing.

I also improved my ability to collaborate with other musicians, both remotely and in person, adapting my workflow when challenges arose.

A key learning point was recognising when a composition was not working (Waking Dream) and making the decision to replace it with a stronger piece (Bless This Mess).

Overall, this project has improved both my technical and creative approach to music production and performance.